

Check the Results

HOW MUCH TO CHECK

AI can help with almost any task. The real skill is knowing how much to check what it gives you. Some answers need a hard look. Others barely need one.

That’s what trust really comes down to here. Not believing the output automatically, but knowing what kind of follow-up it needs before you use it.

SOMETIMES THE ANSWER IS NO

Before the dial even matters, there’s a faster call. Some moments shouldn’t go to AI at all: the sharpest move is to leave the tool closed and handle it yourself, or hand it to a real person.

DON'T REACH FOR IT WHEN

THE RULE ALREADY SAYS NO

- The assignment or policy forbids it.
- You’d be using it to dodge the very skill you’re there to build.

IT INVOLVES PRIVATE INFORMATION

- You’d have to paste your own sensitive details.
- It means handing over someone else’s private information.

YOU CAN'T STAND BEHIND THE RESULT

- You can’t verify whether the output is true.
- It’s a high-stakes call that needs a qualified human.
- It would act under your name without your review.

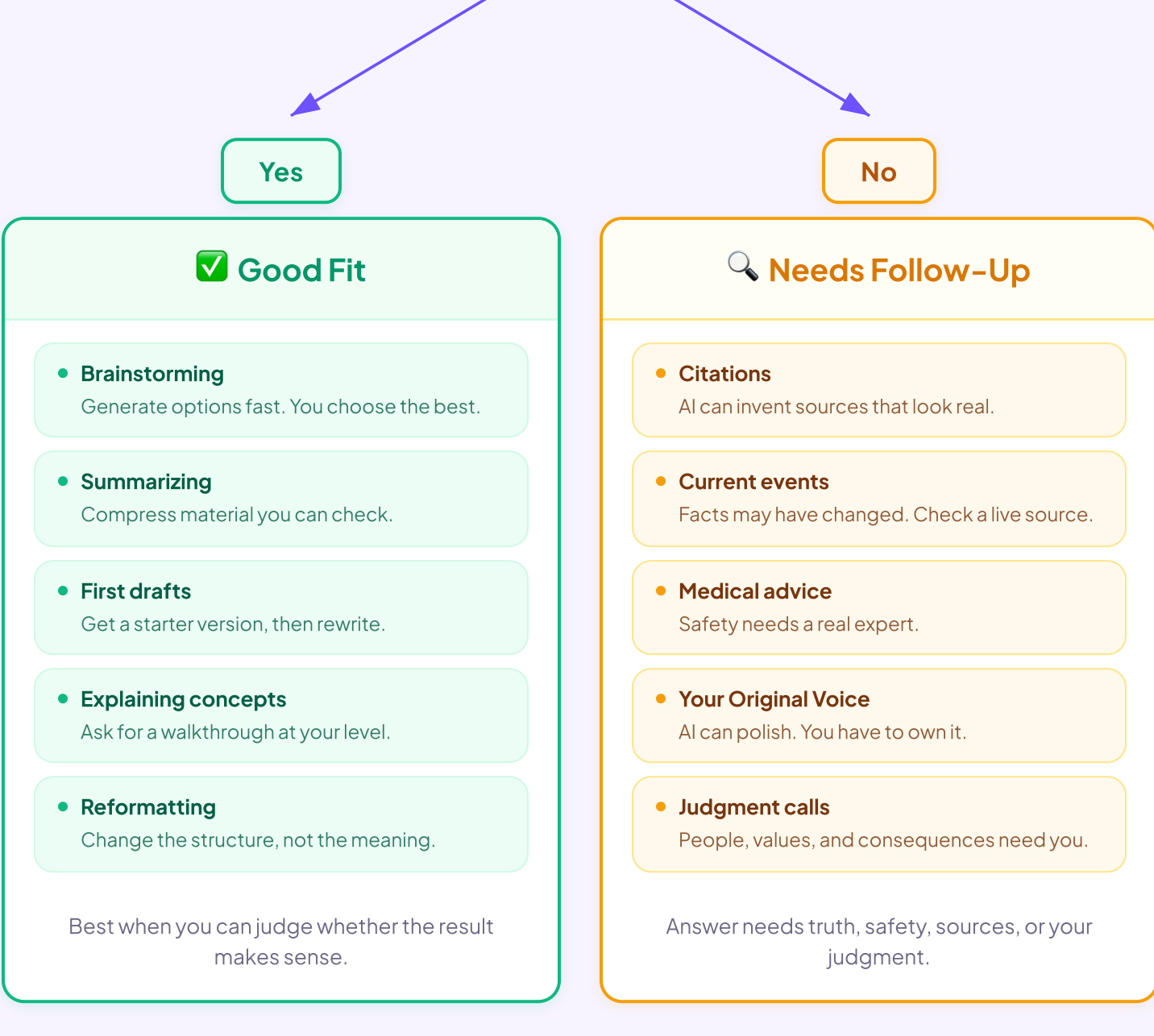
IT'S YOURS, OR IT NEEDS A PERSON

- The task needs your own voice or judgment.
- Someone is in real danger and needs a person, now.

FOR EVERYTHING ELSE, SET THE DIAL

Everything else is fair game. From here, the question becomes how much follow-up the answer needs. Start by naming the **type of task** you are asking AI to do. Some task types are easy to judge on your own and need little follow-up. Other task types almost always need follow-up because the answer has to be true, current, safe, sourced, or genuinely yours.

How Much to Check



Good Fit doesn’t mean ready to use. It means the task matches AI’s strengths and you can judge the result. The final call is still yours.

Now your turn. Below are prompts you might type. Make the call on each: is it a Good Fit, or does it Need Follow-Up?

The real question isn’t “Can AI do this?” It’s “What do I need to check before I use it?” That’s the move judgment makes.

Is this actually good enough to use? You’ve learned how to verify whether AI output is *true*. This section is about whether it’s *usable*: does it actually solve your problem, match your audience, and meet your standard?

WHY EVALUATION MATTERS



Correct doesn’t mean usable

A response can be factually right but still miss the mark: wrong tone, wrong format, incomplete, or answering the wrong question.



Evaluation tells you what to fix

It’s not just pass/fail. It tells you exactly how to refine your prompt for a better result on the next round.

Use these six criteria as a checklist every time you evaluate AI output.

When the output isn’t good enough, don’t start over. Instead, **refine and try again**.

HOW TO REFINE



Don't start over

Build on what worked. If the structure was good but the detail was lacking, ask for more detail. Don’t rewrite the whole prompt.



Be specific about what's wrong

"Make it better" is vague. "Add metrics to each bullet point" is actionable. Tell the model exactly what to fix.



2–3 rounds is normal

Even expert prompt engineers iterate. Think of it like a conversation, not a one-shot command.

Prompt → Evaluate → Refine

01 First attempt

• YOU

Write a summary of the game.

• AI

The basketball game was exciting and competitive. Both teams played hard and showed great sportsmanship. There were many highlights throughout the game. The final score was close and it was a great experience for everyone involved.

EVALUATION

Completely generic. No teams, no score, no details. Could describe literally any game ever played.

→ NEXT STEP

Add specifics: who played, what happened, and the final score.

02 Refined prompt

• YOU

Write a recap of our varsity basketball game against Lincoln High. We won 67–62. Cover: key plays (my 3–pointer to take the lead in the 4th quarter), team stats (I had 18 points, Marcus had 14 rebounds), and what we need to work on (free throw shooting was 55%).

• AI

Varsity takes down Lincoln High 67–62 in a hard-fought battle that came down to the wire. The game was tight through three quarters, with Lincoln holding a slim 51–49 lead heading into the 4th. That changed when a clutch 3–pointer from beyond the arc put us ahead for good. From there, the defense locked in and held Lincoln to just 11 points in the final frame. Key performers: 18 points from the perimeter, including the go-ahead three. Marcus dominated the glass with 14 rebounds, giving us crucial second-chance opportunities. Area to improve: Free throw shooting. We shot just 55% from the line, and in a 5–point game, those missed free throws could have cost us. That’s the focus in practice this week.

EVALUATION

Good structure, but the AI added stuff we never gave it: a "51–49 Lincoln lead heading into the 4th" and "held Lincoln to just 11 points in the final frame." Both made up. Catch the invented details before any polish.

→ NEXT STEP

Cut the made-up numbers, then ask for an Instagram-friendly headline and format.

03 Final polish

• YOU

Cut anything I didn’t give you (the 51–49 lead, the 11–point defensive stat). Then add a bold headline and reformat for Instagram: shorter sentences, line breaks, more energy.

• AI

DUB. 🏀 Varsity 67, Lincoln 62 Down going into the 4th. Hit the 3 to take the lead. Never looked back. 18 pts | Marcus with 14 boards Work to do: 55% from the line. We finish those? That’s a blowout. On to the next one. 🔥

FINAL RESULT

Three rounds got us from a generic nothing summary to a fire Instagram post. Each round was a small refinement, not a complete rewrite.

THE TAKEAWAY

Prompt. Evaluate. Refine. Repeat.

Three rounds got us from a generic summary to a real Instagram post. Each round was a small refinement, not a complete rewrite.

True isn’t enough. The real question is whether the answer is good enough for what you’re about to do with it. A correct sentence in the wrong tone, at the wrong length, missing the point of your question, still fails.

TRUST, THEN CHECK

Is this true? Questioning an answer helps you spot a weak claim anywhere. AI hallucinates in specific ways that need their own toolkit. These six strategies will help you verify AI output before you use it.

You already learned to match the check to the task in How Much to Check: brainstorming, summarizing, and first drafts barely need a look, but facts, citations, and anything touching health, money, or another person do. This lesson is the other half. Once you know an answer needs checking, here is how you actually do it.

Confidence is not consistency. Two polished AI answers can disagree with each other, and both will sound certain. When you’ve asked twice and gotten different answers, don’t average them. The contradiction is the signal. Find the underlying claim and check it against something real.

The strategies below are tools. The judgment is which tool to use for which question.

STACK THEM, DON'T PICK ONE

In practice, you don’t run one strategy. You run several on the same answer. Cross-reference the specific claim. Check any citations. Watch for suspiciously specific numbers. Ask the model to flag what it’s uncertain about. The strategies above are the tools. Verifying is the workflow.

If you can’t find the source, assume it doesn’t exist. Confident wording is not evidence. Fancy formatting is not evidence. A real link to a real source you can read is evidence.

THE SIX CHECKS



Cross-reference the claim

Extract the fact. Search the fact. Don’t trust the sentence.



Verify citations and sources

If you can’t find the source after searching, it was likely fabricated. AI frequently invents plausible-sounding citations.



Don't trust the source link

A sourced answer is better than an unsourced one, but a link doesn’t make a claim true.



Watch for hallucination triggers

The more specific the detail, the more skeptical you should be.

Ask the model to self-check

"Are you sure?" can surface uncertainty or catch mistakes, but it isn’t verification. Treat it as a second pass, then check the claim somewhere real.

Spot the 'almost true' trap

If part of an answer is verifiably true, don’t assume the rest is too.